*The Spirit of Terrorism**

Jean Baudrillard

One has seen global events, from Diana's death to the Soccer World Championship, and violent and real events, from wars to genocides; but never before a symbolic event of global stature, i.e., one that does not merely circulate globally, but jeopardizes globalization. All through the stagnant 1990s, "events went on strike" (in the words of the Argentine writer Macedonio Fernandez). Well, the strike is over. Events have ended the strike. With the attacks on Washington and the WTC, the absolute event, the "mother" of all events — the pure event that embodies within itself all other events which never took place, has arrived.

The whole game of history and power has been turned upside down, as have the conditions of analysis. One must take time to reflect. As long as events were standing still, one had to anticipate and outrun them. But when events accelerate so much, one has to slow down — without becoming engulfed in a jumble of words and in the clouds of war, and without losing sight of the unforgettable flash of images. All speeches and commentaries betray a massive reaction to the event and to its mesmerizing effect. The moral condemnation, the holy union against terrorism, indicate the prodigious elation at seeing this global superpower destroyed — even better, to see it self-destruct, commit suicide in a flourish. This is because, through its unbearable power, it has instigated all this violence throughout the world, and therefore (unknowingly) the terrorist imagination in all of us.

Dreaming about this event (as everyone has, because no one can avoid fantasizing about the destruction of any power that has become so hegemonic) is unacceptable to Western moral consciousness, but it is nevertheless a fact that can be gauged by the pathetic violence of all the speeches that want to erase it. Basically, they did it, but we wanted it. If this is not taken into account, the event loses all symbolic dimensions, becomes a pure accident, a purely arbitrary act, the murderous phantasmagoria of a few fanatics, who can just be eliminated. But that it is not so. This explains all the delirious counter-phobic exorcism of evil: it is here and everywhere, like an obscure object of desire. Without this profound complicity, the event would not have had the impact it had, and in their symbolic strategy the terrorists undoubtedly knew they could count on this inadmissible complicity. This

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goes far beyond the hatred of the underprivileged and the exploited toward the dominant global power, of those who fell on the wrong side of the world order. This malicious desire is at the heart of all those who share the benefits. Fortunately, the allergy against all definitive order, against all definitive power, is universal, and the two WTC towers embodied this definitive order precisely because they were twins.

There is no need for a death-wish or for destruction, nor even for a depraved effect. It is very logical and inexorable that the exercise of power exacerbates the will to destroy it, and that it is an accomplice in its own destruction. When the two towers collapsed, it was as if they countered the suicide of the suicide-planes with their own suicide. It has been said: "Even God cannot declare war against himself." But yes, he can. In the position of God (of all divine powers and of absolute moral legitimacy), the West becomes suicidal and declares war on itself.

Countless disaster movies convey this fantasy, which they obviously conjure with images, enveloping everything in special effects. But, as with pornography, their universal attraction is that they are never too far from being acted out — the will to deny any system becomes stronger the closer the system comes to perfection or to total power. Maybe the terrorists (as well as the experts!) did not expect the collapse of the twin towers, which, much more than the Pentagon, resulted in the strongest symbolic shock. The symbolic collapse of a whole system happened thanks to an unpredictable complicity. It is as if, by collapsing on their own, by committing suicide, the towers participated in finalizing the event.

In a sense, because of its internal fragility, the whole system collaborates with the initial action. The more the system is globally concentrated, constituting but one network, the more vulnerable it becomes at one particular place (a single Philippine hacker had already succeeded, from the depth of his laptop, in launching the virus "I love you," which traveled around the world, devastating complete networks). Here are 18 kamikazes who, thanks to the absolute weapon of death, compounded by technological efficiency, started a catastrophic global process.

When the situation is so monopolized by the global power, when there is this formidable concentration of all functions by the machinery of technocracy and political correctness, what other way is there but a terrorist transformation of the situation? The system creates the objective conditions for that brutal retaliation. Holding all the cards, it forces the Other to change the rules of the game. The new rules are ferocious, because the stakes are so high. To a system whose surplus of power does not allow any challenges, terrorists respond with a definitive act also impossible to duplicate. Terrorism is an act that restores an irreducible particularity in the middle of a generalized exchange system. All particularities (species, individuals, cultures) which today challenge the establishment of global circulation directed by one single power take their revenge with their death through this terrorist transformation of the situation.

Terror against terror — there is no longer any ideology behind all this. It is now well beyond ideology and politics. No ideology, no cause, not even that of

Islam, can justify the energy feeding this terror. Its goal is no longer to transform the world; rather, as with all, it seeks to radicalize the world through sacrifice, while the system wants to achieve its goal through force.

Like a virus, terrorism is everywhere. There is a global spread of terrorism, which is like the shadow projected by every system of domination, ready to be reactivated like a double agent everywhere. There is no longer a demarcation line to define it neatly. It is at the center of the culture it fights against, and the visible fracture (and the hatred) that pits the exploited and the underdeveloped against the Western world secretly feeds into the fracture within the dominant system. The latter can face all visible antagonisms. But the system is helpless against terrorism, which is structured like a virus — as though any system of domination fosters its own anti-system, its own disintegration — against this almost automatic reversal of its own power. Terrorism is the shock wave of this silent reversal.

So the conflict is neither a clash of civilizations nor of religions. It goes far beyond Islam and America, over which the conflict is focused in order to give the illusion of a visible confrontation and of a solution through force. It is really a fundamental antagonism, but one which designates, through the specter of America (which might be the epicenter, but not the only embodiment of globalization) and the specter of Islam (which is also not the embodiment of terrorism), triumphant globalization struggling against itself. In this sense, one can actually talk about a world war, not the third, but the fourth, and the only one really global, because what is at stake is globalization itself. The first two world wars were traditional. The first one put an end to European supremacy and colonialism; the second ended Nazism; and the third, which really took place in the form of a Cold War and *détente*, ended communism. Gradually, each moved the world closer to a univocal world order. Today, through all its current convulsions, the latter is virtually achieved, and faces antagonistic forces everywhere. It is a fractal war of all the different cells, of all particularities, which revolt in the form of antibodies. It is a confrontation so elusive that, from time to time, one has to save the idea of war with spectacular set-ups, like the one in the Gulf, or, today, the one in Afghanistan. But the fourth world war is elsewhere. It haunts every global order, all hegemonic domination. If Islam dominated the world, terrorism would rise up against Islam, since it is the world which resists globalization.

Terrorism is immoral. The WTC event, this symbolic provocation, is immoral, and it is an answer to a globalization that is immoral. So, if one wants to understand anything, one must go beyond good and evil and become immoral. For once, there is an event that not only defies morality, but also any kind of interpretation. So how should evil be understood? The crucial point is precisely this: as far as the relation between good and evil is concerned, it is in complete opposition to Western philosophy and the Enlightenment. People naively believe that the progress of good, its rise to power in all fields (scientific, technical, democratic, human rights) corresponds to the defeat of evil. Nobody seems to understand that good and evil

increase their power simultaneously, following the same curve. One's triumph does not lead to the other's demise; quite the contrary. Metaphysically, evil is considered an accidental blunder, but this axiom, from which all Manichean forms of the struggle of good against evil derive, is an illusion. Good does not diminish evil. It is more the opposite: neither can be reduced, and their relation is inextricable. Ultimately, good could only defeat evil by renouncing to be good, because, by globally monopolizing power, it would result in a reaction of proportional violence.

In a traditional universe, there was still a balance between good and evil, according to a dialectical relation, which maintained at all costs the tension and balance of the moral universe — a little like the face-off the two powers maintained during the Cold War, assuring a balance of terror. So there is no supremacy of one over the other. This balance is broken when there is a complete extrapolation of the good (hegemony of the positive over all forms of negativity, exclusion of death and of any other adverse power — the triumph of the values of good all the way). From there, the balance is broken, and it is as if evil would recover an invisible autonomy and develop exponentially.

To some extent, that is what happened in politics with the disappearance of communism and the global triumph of liberal power: that is when a ghostly enemy appeared, intruding on the entire planet, infiltrating everywhere like a virus, reappearing in all the cracks of power: Islam. But Islam is only the moving front of the crystallization of this antagonism, which is everywhere and in everyone. So, it is terror against terror. But it is an asymmetrical terror. And it is this asymmetry that leaves the global superpower completely disarmed. Confronting itself, it can only sink into its own logic of power relations, unable to play on the field of symbolic provocation and death, having no idea what it is, because it has eliminated it from its own culture.

So far, this integrating power has succeeded in absorbing all crises, all negativity, thus creating a fundamentally desperate situation (not only for the damned of the earth, but also for the well-off in their radical comfort). The fundamental event is that terrorists no longer commit suicide in vain, but put their lives in danger in an antagonistic and efficient manner, following a strategic intuition, which is nothing but the immense fragility of the opponent, of a system that is almost perfect, and therefore vulnerable to the slightest spark. They succeeded in turning their own death into an absolute weapon against a system predicated on the exclusion of death, whose ideal is "zero-death." Every "zero-death" system is a zero-sum system, and all means of dissuasion and destruction are powerless against an enemy who has already turned his own death into a counter-offensive weapon. So, everything is about death, not only through its brutal occurrence seen live and in real time, but through an even more real eruption of death, i.e., symbolic and sacrificial death, i.e., the absolute event without possibility of appeal. Such is the spirit of terrorism.

Never attack the system in terms of a power struggle. This is the (revolutionary) imaginary that the system imposes, which can only survive by constantly

bringing those who attack it to fight on the field of a reality that is always its own. Instead, place the struggle in the symbolic sphere, where the rule is provocation, reversal, and escalation, so that one death can only be answered by an equal or superior death. Defy the system with a gift it cannot counter, except with its own death or its own collapse. The terrorist hypothesis is that the system commits suicide, responding to multiple death and suicide provocations, because neither the system nor power can evade the symbolic obligation, and the only chance for their disaster relies on this trap: In the vertiginous cycle of the impossible exchange of death. The death of the terrorist is an infinitesimal point, but one which induces an aspiration, an emptiness, and a gigantic convection. The whole system of reality and power becomes concentrated, is paralyzed, shrinks, and collapses around this tiny point, through its own super-efficiency.

The tactic of the terrorist model is to provoke a surplus of reality and to make the whole system collapse under it. The irony of the situation is that the violence mobilized by power turns against it, for terrorist acts are simultaneously an exorbitant mirror of its own violence and the model for a symbolic violence that it cannot use, the only violence it cannot deploy, i.e., the violence of its own death.

That is why all visible power can do nothing against the tiny, but symbolic death of a few individuals. It must be realized that a new terrorism is born — a new form of action that plays the game and appropriates the rules for itself, so it can better upset them. Not only do these people not fight with the same weapons, because they use their own deaths, to which there is no possible answer ("they are cowards"), but they also appropriate all the weapons of the dominant power. Money and stock speculations, computer and aeronautical technologies, the spectacular dimension and media networks — they have completely adopted modernity and globalization without changing their course, which is to destroy it.

As their most cunning trick, the terrorists even used the banality of American everyday life as a mask and a double play: sleeping in suburbs, reading and studying in a family environment, before going off one day like a time bomb. The perfect mastery of this secrecy is almost as much a terrorist act as the spectacular act of Sept. 11. Since it turns every individual into a suspect, does it not also turn all innocent persons into potential terrorists? If those individuals can go unnoticed, every one becomes an unnoticed criminal (every airplane becomes similarly suspect), and ultimately it may be true. Maybe it really corresponds to an unconscious form of potential criminality, masked and carefully repressed, yet always prone if not to resurface, at least to secretly vibrate at the sight of evil. So the event branches out into the smallest details — the source of a mental and even more subtle terrorism.

The fundamental difference is that, with the system's weapons, the terrorists have at their disposal a lethal weapon: their own death. If they limited themselves to fighting the system with its own weapons, they would be immediately eliminated. If the system were to counter them with its own death, they would just as quickly disappear in a pointless sacrifice — as terrorism has almost always done

(the Palestinian suicide-attacks), which is why they were bound to fail. Everything changes as soon as they combine all available modern means with this highly symbolic weapon. That compounds *ad infinitum* the destructive potential. It is this multiplication of elements (which, seem irreconcilable) that gives them such superiority. But, the "zero-death" strategy, that of a "proper" technological war, misses precisely this transfiguration of "real" into symbolic power. The fabulous success of such an attack poses a problem, and in order to understand anything it is necessary to step back from the Western perspective to see what is going on in their organization and in their heads.

Such efficiency would require a maximum amount of calculation, i.e., a rationality difficult to imagine others have. And even in this case, as in any other rational organization or secret service, there would have always been leaks and blunders. So the secret of such a success lies elsewhere. The difference is that for them it is not a matter of an employment contract, but of a pact, a sacrificial obligation. Such an obligation is safe from defection or corruption. The miracle is to have adjusted to the global network, to the technical protocol, without losing any of the complicity between life and death. Unlike a contract, a pact does not bind individuals — even their "suicide" is not an individual heroism, but a collective sacrificial act sealed by an ideal requirement. And it is the combination of the two systems, an operational structure and a symbolic pact, which made possible an act of such dimensions.

A symbolic calculation, as used in a poker game or a potlatch: minimal stakes, maximum results, remains a mystery. This is exactly what the terrorists achieved with the Manhattan attack, which would pretty well explain chaos theory: an initial shock precipitating incalculable consequences, while the huge American deployment (Desert Storm) had only trivial results — the hurricane ending, so to say, with the fluttering of butterfly wings. Suicidal terrorism used to be a poor man's terrorism; this one is a rich man's terrorism. And this is what is frightening: they became rich (they have all the means), but they do not stop wishing for the West's demise. Indeed, according to the Western value system, they are cheating: it is not fair to jeopardize one's own life. But they do not care, and the new rules of the game are not up to the West anymore.

Everything is fair game to discredit the terrorists' actions, as it is to call them "suicidal" and "martyrs," and to add immediately that a martyr does not prove anything, that he has nothing to do with the truth, even that he is (quoting Nietzsche) truth's number one enemy. Indeed, their death does not prove anything, but there is nothing to prove in a system where truth is elusive. But, this highly moral argument reverses itself. If the voluntary martyrdom of kamikazes does not prove anything, then the involuntary martyrdom of the victims of the attack does not prove anything either, and there is something improper and obscene in making it a moral argument (this does not prejudge in any way their suffering and death).

Another argument made in bad faith: these terrorists trade their death for a place in paradise. Their action is not free; therefore it is not authentic. It would

only be free if they did not believe in God, if death would be hopeless (although the Christian martyrs did not expect anything more than this sublime equivalence). So, once again, they do not fight on a level field, since they are entitled to a salvation Westerners can no longer hope for. In fact, all this — the cause, the proof, the truth, the reward, the end, and the means — are all typical Western forms of calculation. Even death is evaluated in terms of interest rates, of good or bad returns for one's money. It is an economic calculation — the calculation of the poor who do not even have the courage to put a price on it. What can happen — except war, which is only a conventional protective screen? There is talk of bio-terrorism, bacteriological warfare, or nuclear terrorism. None of this is on the level of symbolic provocation, rather it is on the level of annihilation without words, without glory, without risk — on the level of the final solution.

It is inconsistent to see in the terrorists' acts a purely destructive logic. It seems that their own death is part of their acts (that is precisely what makes it symbolic) and not at all of the impersonal elimination of the Other. Everything is in the provocation and in the duel, i.e., in a personal relation with the opposite power. It has humiliated, so it has to be humiliated. It cannot be merely exterminated: it has to lose face. This cannot be accomplished by pure force or by the elimination of the Other. The latter has to be targeted and wounded in full enmity. In addition to the pact that binds the terrorists, there is something of a mutual pact with the opponent. It is exactly the opposite of the cowardliness they are blamed for, and it is exactly the opposite of what, e.g., the Americans did in the Gulf War (and are now doing in Afghanistan): invisible targets, operational liquidations. The pregnancy of these images and their fascination must be saved, because, like it or not, they are original impressions. The New York events have radicalized the relation between image and reality, at the same time that they have radicalized the global situation. Since there were only an uninterrupted flow of trivial images and bogus events, the New York terrorist attack has revived both the image and the event.

Among the system's weapons, the terrorists also exploited the immediacy of the images — their instant broadcasting world-wide. They appropriated them like they did stock speculations, electronic information, or air traffic. The function of images is highly ambiguous. While these images glorify the event, they also take it hostage. They can compound *ad infinitum*, and simultaneously act as a diversion and a neutralization (as was already the case with the 1968 events). What one always forgets when talking about the "danger" of the media is that the image consumes the event, in the sense that it absorbs it and prepares it for consumption. Indeed, it gives the event new vigor, but as an image-event.

What happens then to the real event, when image, fiction, and virtual reality intrude everywhere on reality? In this case, one thought (maybe with a certain relief) that there was a resurgence of the real — of the violence of the real — in a supposedly virtual universe. "Forget about the virtual — this is real!" In the same way, one could see a revival of history, beyond its projected end. But does reality

really go beyond fiction? If this seems to be the case, it is because reality absorbed the energy of fiction, and became fiction. One could almost say that reality is as jealous of fiction as the real is jealous of the image. . . . It is a kind of duel between them: which one will be the most unimaginable?

The collapse of the WTC is unimaginable, but that is not enough to make it a real event. An increase of violence is not enough to open up to reality. For reality is a principle, and it is this principle that is lost. The real and the fiction are inextricable, and the fascination of the attack is in the first place the fascination for the image (the consequences, at the same time elating and disastrous, are largely imaginary). So, in this case, the real adds a bonus of terror to the image, like an additional thrill. Not only is it terrifying, it is also real. Rather than having first the violence of the real and the thrill of the image following it, the image is there first, and the thrill of the real comes later. It is something like an additional fiction — a fiction going beyond fiction. Ballard (after Borges) used to talk about reinventing the real as the ultimate and most frightening fiction.

Thus, this terrorist violence does not amount to reality backfiring, any more than to history backfiring. This terrorist violence is not "real." In a way, it is even worse: it is symbolic. In itself, violence can be perfectly trivial and harmless. Only symbolic violence generates particularity. In this particular event, this Manhattan-disaster movie, the two elements of 20th century mass fascination are intimately combined: the white magic of movies and the black magic of terrorism. The white light of the image and the black light of terrorism.

Afterwards, one tries to give it some meaning, some interpretation. But there is none, and the only thing original and implacable is the show's extremism and brutality. The spectacle of terrorism introduces the terrorism of the spectacle. And the political order is powerless against this immoral fascination (even if it precipitates a universal moral reaction). It is a theater of cruelty, the only one remaining — extraordinary, because it combines the most spectacular with the most provocative. It is simultaneously a terrific micro-model of a core of real violence with the most repercussions — the purest form of the spectacular — and a sacrificial model that imposes on the historical and political order the purest symbolic form of provocation. One could forgive the terrorists any killing, if it had a meaning, if it could be interpreted as historical violence — this is the moral axiom of good violence. One could forgive them any violence, were it not taken over by the media ("Terrorism is nothing without the media"). But all this is an illusion. There is no good use of the media. The media are part of the event, they are part of the terror, and they go either way.

The repressive act follows the same unpredictable spiral as the terrorist act; nobody knows where it will stop, and which reversal of the situation will follow. There is no possible distinction, as far as images and information are concerned, between the spectacular and the symbolic. There is no possible distinction between "crime" and repression. This uncontrollable outburst of reversibility is

terrorism's true victory. It is a victory visible in the event's underground ramifications and infiltrations — not only in the direct, economic, political, financial recession of the whole system, and in the resulting moral and psychological recession, but also in the recession involving the value system, the whole ideology of freedom, the freedom of movement, etc., which was the pride of the Western world, and which it boasted to rule over the rest of the world. So much so that the concept of freedom, a new and recent concept, is already being erased from customs and consciousness, and that liberal globalization is taking the exact opposite form: that of totalitarian globalization, absolute control, and the terror of safety. Deregulation ends up with as many constraints as those of a fundamentalist society. It means decreases in production, consumption, speculation and economic growth (but certainly not corruption). It is as if the global system were making a strategic withdrawal, an agonizing reconsideration of its values — in a seemingly defensive reaction to terrorism, but responding in fact to secret injunctions. It is a forced regulation resulting from absolute chaos, one it imposes on itself, internalizing in some way its own defeat.

Another aspect of the terrorists' victory is that all other forms of violence and destabilization of the order play in its favor: computer terrorism, biological terrorism, anthrax, and rumor terrorism. Bin Laden is blamed for everything. He could even claim responsibility for natural disasters. All forms of disorganization and perverse circulation benefit him. Even the structure of generalized global exchange plays in the favor of the impossible exchange. It is like an automatic writing of terrorism, powered and fed by the involuntary terrorism of information, with all the resulting panic. If, in this anthrax story, intoxication occurs through instant crystallization; like a chemical solution coming in contact with a molecule, the system has reached a critical mass, which makes it vulnerable to any aggression.

There is no solution to this extreme state of affairs — especially not war, which can only recycle a previous situation, with the same flood of military forces, ghostly information, pointless bludgeoning, deceitful and pathetic speeches, technological deployment and intoxication. In short, it is like the Gulf War: a non-event, which did not really take place. Its only *raison d'être* is to substitute a real, formidable, unique, and unpredictable event with a recurrent pseudo-event. The terrorist attack corresponded to an event preceeding all models of interpretation, while the stupidly military and technological war corresponds to a superimposition of the model over the event, i.e., an artificial stake, and to a dismissal: the war is a continuation of the lack of politics by other means.